

Spyware: This is a sensitive issue, and people have different views about spyware. It's the same reason why many of us use Google's Gmail service, while others still refuse to because Google claims to have a robot read your mails and display relevant advertisements. Honestly, I don't care if a machine reads even my most intimate e-mails, but many do. It's just a matter of choice really. So as long as you don't store passwords and credit card information on your computer, or within your browser, you have nothing to worry about.

Hackers: Yes, many of us are paranoid about being hacked. The fact is, unless you work for an atomic power plant, are an aide to the Prime Minister, or have a T3 line at home, 99.9999999999999999 per cent of hackers couldn't be interested in your home computer that connects to the Net via dial-up or even a 'broad-(hah!)-band' connection! If someone actually tried to hack you, it would only be to test his or her skills and then move on. Why? Well, I hate to be the one to break it to you... but you just aren't important enough! No one wants to hack your computer and look at pictures of the family dog, your trip to Mussoorie, or your baby photographs! Hackers have a purpose, they want money, information, control, or access to another more secure computer on your network. The majority of home computers in India offer none of these: you don't store credit card information on your PCs (hopefully), you have no information of global importance, your connection speed (or lack thereof) makes your computer useless for participation in DDoS attacks, and it's not like you're on the same network as the RBI or the US Department of Defense!

Online Cons

These happen! Unfortunately, this rarely has anything to do with anyone's computer; instead, it's more to do with the person controlling the mouse and keyboard! Alas, it's stupidity that most online con-artists prey upon, and not weak passwords or hacked computers!

Most of us laugh at some of the e-mails we receive, supposedly from Nigerian princes or Saudi oil barons, claiming that if you let them deposit millions of dollars in your account they'll tip you with a few thousand. Sure, 99 per cent of

us just hit [Delete], but that one-in-every-hundredth person makes the con-artists' efforts worthwhile!

There was a story in leading newspapers, early in January 2006, about an Indian girl who gave out her Internet banking password to a prospective groom. The picture in her head was of a young, handsome, jet-setting executive who traversed the globe; the reality was a 50+ man who successfully conned her out of over Rs 2 lakh! Love, especially the online kind, ladies and gentlemen, can be a very sharp double-edged sword. Though most of us tch-tched at the story, you never can tell what you would have done in the same situation!

Advice

I am told that I have to offer some form of advice or another if I want this little rant to ever get published. So here it is, my four cents worth on how you can prevent lapses in security:

- ❑ Don't ever store credit card information on your computer
- ❑ Storing passwords in your browser is a no-no, and you should remember to clean your browser cache regularly
- ❑ Make sure you store everything that's important to you on a drive that's different from the one that the OS is loaded on, and always set all your "anti-" software to update automatically!
- ❑ Never—and I mean Never—trust anyone! Especially someone you have only met online. Never part with credit card details and Internet banking passwords—especially with your shop-till-you-drop better-halves!

But all this sounds like I am feeding your already overactive imagination, making you even more paranoid than before. In truth, I am just stating the obvious, because some of us tend to forget even that. Personally, I feel it's more important to heed the advice that follows:

1. Never take things too seriously! Spyware on your system does not mean that all your deepest darkest secrets are now part of the public domain. It probably just explains why your browser navigates to some silly site, and nothing more.
2. Try not to hyperventilate every time you see a message on your system that contains the word "virus". What is the point of such panic after all? If your anti-virus found some malicious code, it obvi-

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ously cannot harm you. If the anti-virus let a virus slip by undetected, you won't know until it's too late anyway. So in actuality, there's nothing any of us can do to stop our PCs from attempted infection, or even infection itself.

3. Realise that you and your home computer are really just motes in a desert of computers, so being paranoid about spyware, adware and Trojans is like thinking that the entire world of hackers is out to get you. This is perhaps a little too narcissistic, isn't it?

4. Try not to drop tea on the ground. If you do, clean it up immediately—it really can leave a terrible stain if it's not cleaned up for a while!

Moving On

This experience of mine has been akin to seeing the fabled light. I now waste less time looking through what services and threads are running on my computer, and more time enjoying myself actually using what I have. I have begun trying out more software, visiting more sites that ask me to install ActiveX components and running a lot less spyware checks, ever since I saw the futility of being paranoid. Overall, my computing experience has become a lot more fun!

Perhaps I will start a support group—PTA: Paranoid Techies Anonymous—where people can stand up and say, “Hi, I’m Jon, and it’s been 4 days since I last ran SpyBot S & D and AdAware!”, and hand out cookies to those who share their secret methods of staying paranoia-free.

I've also formatted my C: drive once, just for the heck of it, and found, intrestingly, that despite the fact that I was paranoid about security and an obsessive-compulsive tweaker, Windows XP still runs the fastest just after a clean format-and-reinstall!

Big brothers, mothers, fathers, sisters and hackers alike listen up, "Heres one computer user who can stay smart, secure and unworried. After all, I am armed with weapons of my own: a Windows XP boot disk, a DVD of all my favourite freeware and an 80 GB external hard disk that has all my important data, movies and music! So give it your best shot, the worst thing that could happen is that I format my PC and get a faster computer as a result!" ☒

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